



ISFAHAN IRAN

Khoresh-e Fesenjan in Isfahan

As the call to prayer rises from its minarets, Isfahan's famous mosque, Masjid-e Emam, glitters in the late afternoon sun. In the nearby bazaar, the air is filled with the scent of spices, and toward the city's edge an ancient fire temple is silhouetted against low, jagged hills. There is no more atmospheric place to sample *khoresh-e fesenjan*, one of the most opulent dishes in Persian cuisine.



Isfahan is an unforgettable place.

Imagine a square – originally a polo ground – surrounded by some of the most exquisitely

beautiful architecture to be found anywhere in the Islamic world. The Persian capital during the 16th and 17th centuries, Isfahan is for many synonymous with the art and architecture of Iran – refined palaces, elegant gardens, and mosques lavishly decorated with dazzling blue and turquoise tiles.

Iran (Persia) has an exceptionally long history. It was already a formidable empire some 2,500 years ago, against which first the Greeks and then the Romans measured themselves. Though there are plenty of signs of this long history in Isfahan, the city is most closely associated with the Safavid period, when the great ruler Shah Abbas turned it into his capital in the late 16th century. He laid out the Meydan-e Emam (a huge square) together with the Masjid-e Emam (the famous royal mosque on the south side of the square) and the smaller Masjid-e Lotfollah mosque. These buildings still constitute one of the greatest architectural ensembles on the planet, and along with the Meydan-e Emam are inscribed on the UNESCO World Heritage list.

The cuisine of the Persian empire also developed over the course of many centuries, and is equally refined. *Khoresh* is the Persian word for a stew or sauce, and it comes in many guises, of which *fesenjan* is one of the best known and certainly one of the richest. This dish – also called the king of stews – is often prepared at home for special occasions. Chicken, or more traditionally duck, is simmered with onion, ground toasted walnuts, and pomegranate syrup until literally falling off the bone. The resulting sauce is a rich, dark brown, with an exquisite sweet-bitter flavor from the walnuts, pomegranate, lemon, and cinnamon. Some say the dish originates in northern Iran, though it can be found across the country – at least, in restaurants serving a range of dishes rather than just kebabs, the nation's favorite fast food.

Khoresh-e fesenjan is served with rice, cooked slowly to perfection and topped with melting butter, a serving of tasty yogurt, and a wedge of the golden crust (called *tah-dig* in Persian) that forms at the bottom of the rice pan. This is the best part of the dish, as far as many Iranians are concerned. Of course, this being Iran, you won't be drinking wine with your meal – think more in terms of a glass of cool mineral water.

A Day in Isfahan

Most of Isfahan's main sights, including the Meydan-e Emam and the bazaar, are north of the Zayandeh River, while the Armenian quarter and a few other places lie south.

MORNING Start with the **Masjid-e Jame**, a 12th-century masterpiece that has an amazing carved stucco prayer niche from the Mongol period. Then walk through the streets of the **bazaar** to the **Meydan-e Emam**, the vast square laid out at the close of the 16th century, and visit the magnificent **Masjid-e Emam**.

AFTERNOON Visit other buildings on the Meydan-e Emam, including the breathtaking **Masjid-e Lotfollah** and **Ali Qapu Palace**, then take a short walk to the **Hasht Behesht Palace** in the gardens nearby. Share a taxi to the old Armenian quarter of **New Julfa**, with its fascinating churches.

EVENING Return to the river, ducking under one end of the **Si-o Se** bridge to stop at the atmospheric teahouse beneath the arches. Walk to **Restoran-e Shahrzad** in the centre of the city for *khoresh-e fesenjan*.

Essentials

GETTING THERE

Iranian Air and other Gulf states airlines fly into Isfahan's **airport**. There are **shared taxis** to the city 15 miles (25 km) away. **Trains** run from Tehran.

WHERE TO STAY

Amir Kabir Hostel (inexpensive) is the most popular low budget option. +98 311 222 7273
Hotel Julfa (moderate) in the Armenian quarter is another good choice. +98 311 624 4441
Hasht Behesht Apartment Hotel (moderate) is modern and just five minutes from the Meydan-e Emam. www.ehbhotel.webs.com

FURTHER INFORMATION

www.isfahan.ir

